

HUM 2101: Sociology and Disaster Management

Social research methods and key sociology terms

Week 7-8

Society

Society is a group of people living together, sharing common laws, traditions, and values. They interact through work, family, and social activities, following rules that maintain order. People support each other to meet their needs, creating an organized community with institutions like schools, governments, and businesses. Society can include various institutions like schools, governments, businesses, and religious organizations, all contributing to the overall structure and well-being of the community.



Community

A community is a group of people who live in the same area or share a common interest or goal. They support each other, share resources, and often have common values and traditions. Members of a community interact regularly, working together to improve their well-being and solve local problems.

Communities can range from small neighborhoods to larger groups connected by shared interests, such as online communities or professional organizations.

It is also a place where people solve problems together.



Association

An association is a group of people or organizations that come together for a common purpose or interest. They work collectively to achieve shared goals, often through meetings, activities, and projects. Associations can focus on various areas such as professional development, hobbies, social causes, or industry standards. Members benefit from networking, support, and resources provided by the association.



Difference between society and association

Society	Association
Originally society is prior to association. It is older than association.	Originally association is later to society. It is younger than society.
Society may be organized or unorganized	Association is always organized
Society is formed for welfare of mass	Association is formed to fulfill some goals or needs
Society is permanent	Association is temporary in nature. In some cases, it's permanency is relative.
Society is natural	Association is temporary in nature
Society is a complex web of social relationship	Association is a collection of individuals
Membership is compulsory	Membership is voluntary.

Institution

- An institution is an established organization or foundation that serves a specific purpose in society. Examples are schools, hospitals, banks, and governments. Institutions have rules and systems to work properly and provide services like education, healthcare, money management, and making laws. They are important for helping and supporting people in the community.



Difference between association and community

Association	Community
Membership of an association is voluntary. Individuals are at liberty to join them.	By birth itself, individuals become members of community. In this way, membership is rather compulsory.
An association has some specific interest or interests.	A community has some general interests.
An association does not necessarily imply the spatial objects.	A community is marked by locality.
An association may be stable and long-lasting or it may not be so.	A community is relatively more stable and permanent.

Difference between association and institution

Association	Institution
An association is a group of people organized for the purpose of fulfilling a need or needs	Institution refers to the organized way of doing things. It represents common procedure.
It denotes membership. We belong to associations, political parties, trade unions, youth clubs, families etc.	It denotes only a mode or means of service.
It consists of individuals	It consists of laws, rules and regulations
They are concrete	They are abstract
An association has a location. It makes sense to ask where it is. Thus, a family can be located in space	It does not have locations

What is Research?

Research is a way for people to learn about a topic. It involves gathering information, asking questions, and looking at the results to understand something better or solve a problem. Researchers use different methods like experiments, surveys, and observations.

Goals of Research

The main goal of research is to discover new knowledge or improve what we already know.

Types of Research Methods

Surveys

- **What is a Survey?**

A survey is a way to collect information from people by asking them questions, either through a questionnaire or an interview.

- **Why Use Surveys?**

Surveys are popular because they allow people to answer questions anonymously, which can make them more honest.

- **Types of Questions:**

- **Closed-ended Questions:** These are questions with specific answers, like "yes" or "no," or multiple-choice options. They collect numerical data that can be counted and analyzed.
- **Open-ended Questions:** These allow for more detailed answers, where participants can share their thoughts and feelings in their own words. This type of data is more subjective and can vary widely between people.

Field Research

- **What is Field Research?**

This involves going out into the real world to gather information directly. Researchers observe and collect data from people or places related to their study.

- **Why Use Field Research?**

It helps researchers understand real-life situations better than if they were just in a lab.

Participant Observation

- **What is Participant Observation?**

In this method, researchers join in the daily activities of the group they are studying. They observe social interactions and behaviors to understand the group's culture and dynamics better.

Ethnography

- **What is Ethnography?**

This is a deep study of a specific culture or group. Researchers live with the group and observe their daily lives, interactions, and customs. This helps them understand what is important to that group.

Experiments

- **What are Experiments?**

Researchers conduct experiments to test ideas or theories. They look at relationships between different things to see if their hypothesis (an educated guess) is correct.

Types of Experiments:

- **Lab Experiments** : Conducted in a controlled environment where researchers can manage conditions and gather data quickly.
- **Field Experiments**: Conducted in natural settings where researchers cannot control the environment, but the data may be more accurate because it reflects real-life situations.

Secondary Data Analysis

- **What is Secondary Data Analysis?**

This involves using data that others have already collected, rather than gathering new data. Researchers might look at previous studies, historical records, newspapers, or other sources to contribute to their understanding of a topic.